

DRY LANDS

At midday, hot, dusty, dry lands are quiet and appear to be empty. Only at sunrise and sunset, when the air and ground are cooler, do birds come out of the shade to feed and find water. Elf owls are lucky—they eat juicy meat and do not need to drink. Sandgrouse eat dry seeds and have to fly up to 75 miles (120 kilometers) every day to get a drink of water.



Takeout water

Male sandgrouse sit in puddles! Their belly feathers soak up water like sponges. When they return to their nests, the chicks drink from the soggy coat.

After the cold desert night, roadrunners warm up by standing with their backs to the sun and sunbathing.

Roadrunners use their tail to balance as they zigzag across the desert.

Roadrunners run, but they can also fly.

Roadrunners can run as fast as an Olympic sprinter!

Shaggy crest

In cartoons, roadrunners say “beep beep!” In real life, they rattle their beak to make a “clack.”

Roadrunners are about 12 inches (30 cm) tall and live in Mexico and North America.

Roadrunners swallow rattlesnakes that are up to 24 inches (60 centimeters) long.

Like most ground-feeding birds, roadrunners have long legs and toes.



Sandgrouse suck

Most birds have to tip their heads back to make water trickle down their throats. Sandgrouse are unusual—like you, they can suck.

